pages of *The Hindu* and has now hit the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company'.[22] On their return from Surat—what K.R. Guruswami Aiyar termed, 'the Surat tragedy'—some of the shareholders, no doubt instigated by Guruswami Aiyar himself, raised the question 'whether the time had not come when we should separate the company from him?'[23] But taking action was not easy. Though SSNCo was VOC's brainchild and he was the driving force behind it, his formal position was that of an assistant secretary. This far-from-exalted position was however enshrined in the Articles of Association of SSNCo. As a founding document registered with the registrar of joint stock companies, an amendment passed by the general body of shareholders was required if he was to be removed. Further, as Guruswami Aiyar himself conceded, VOC 'had done honest work' and that rather 'zealously' until then; he had managed to raise Rs 3 lakh i.e. a good half of the share capital.[24]

By late January 1908, K.R. Guruswami Aiyar's manoeuvres yielded fruit. Virtually the full control of SSNCo passed to the hands of moderate directors led by A. Sundara Sastri.[25] The move began to relieve VOC from his assistant secretaryship. But the defenestration was not easy. How to convince shareholders in far-off places from all-over the presidency and even beyond—who had subscribed largely, if not solely, on the strength of VOC's Swadeshi propaganda and not on the presumed business acumen of some vakils and merchants? As Guruswami Aiyar confessed to the governor, 'We waited for some opportunity to see that Chidambaram Pillai was considered an obnoxious person in other districts also.'[26] He also feared a lawsuit could be triggered by some precipitate action such as VOC's forcible expulsion.[27] Considering it 'imprudent' to make this change in a transparent and open way, 'a more tactful manner'—to corner VOC into resigning—was adopted. 'Unless [a] paid office was given him for a little while after that [i.e. removal from his statutory position], the whole thing could not have been achieved.' 'It was a tactful step taken', Guruswami Aiyar shamelessly confessed to the Governor, 'to get rid of him as Assistant Secretary …'[28] (This far from pleased the governor who still